

A Family History (The Historian)

& The historian doesn't get fever¹
& The historian doesn't fold his papers into fourths²
& The historian doesn't crawl wordlessly underneath a jet wing³
& The historian doesn't change the name on his passport⁴
& The historian doesn't forget his wedding day⁵
& The historian doesn't drive a truck,⁶ doesn't
 Thread a needle,⁷ doesn't
 Draw blood,⁸ doesn't
 Sell cookies,⁹ doesn't
 Teach gym,¹⁰ doesn't
 Work late¹¹
& The historian never documents a car crash in Nova Scotia¹²
& The historian never warns his children¹³
& The historian never flinches at glass tables¹⁴
& The historian never guesses at stories¹⁵
& The historian gets to know—

¹ From "Don't Write History as Poetry" by Mahmoud Darwish.

² My dad used to tell me how his grandmother would make him fold toilet paper into fourths in order to save it, a habit she picked up from the Great Depression.

³ My great grandfather (on my mom's side) was a very silent man who only spoke when he had something important to say, who engineered military planes for America.

⁴ 1. My grandfather (on my mom's side) changed his name from Smelnick to Scott. Smelnick was already Americanized. 2. I changed mine, too.

⁵ When interviewing my grandmother (on my mom's side) for a school project, she couldn't recall the details of her wedding day, only that she was married in a rabbi's study and that her parents did not come.

⁶ My grandfather (on my dad's side) was a trucker.

⁷ The women of my family taught me to sew.

⁸ My grandmother (on my dad's side) was a nurse.

⁹ My grandfather (on my mom's side) drove around my mother's Long Island neighborhood and sold cookies, while her best friend's dad sold milk.

¹⁰ My grandmother (on my mom's side) taught gym at a school in Queens, NY.

¹¹ My family is one of self-described "workaholics," one of people who have said at one point or another that they'll work until they die.

¹² My mom's old boss, Dorothy Cann Hamilton, died in a car crash while driving through Nova Scotia, Canada. It was the first time I ever saw my mom cry.

¹³ I've grown up being warned by my parents about painkillers, about our family's history of addiction, about how some relatives have become "brain dead."

¹⁴ My great grandmother (on my dad's side) used to yell at my dad for touching her glass tables and leaving fingerprints. He also cut his head open on a coffee table and now has a scar, though I don't think the incidents were related.

¹⁵ This poem is almost all I know.

Abecedarian for Two Hundred and Fifty Years

Another proof of existence,
Burrowing,
Carving by step into stone.
Depth as a measure for time:
Every trace working further into the Earth
Fossilized in the sediment
Gone, cocooned in the ground as if in metamorphosis,
History a moth, unfolding dampened wings
In a darkened womb,
Jolting to life. Do you
Know what is under you? Do you stop to
Listen, to wonder with your ear pressed to a
Meadow? Another cycle of
Nights, of campfire lullabies slung high
Over the moon's sloped shoulders, the moon that eavesdropped on every
Person and every poem that eroded to just
Question, the moon carried our
retiring lives, that guided these moths to
 migrate and dry out on the frosted glass of a light shaped like a breast.
Stories, old stories of suffering,
Tense up
Underground, hearing above, the rhythm of
Violence. Why do we go to
War? Why do we not quench these grasses with
Warning, let the past climb our veins as water climbs the
Xylem? Some do—slowly, timidly—leaning towards
Yesterday, towards a people at their
Zenith.